

Red team

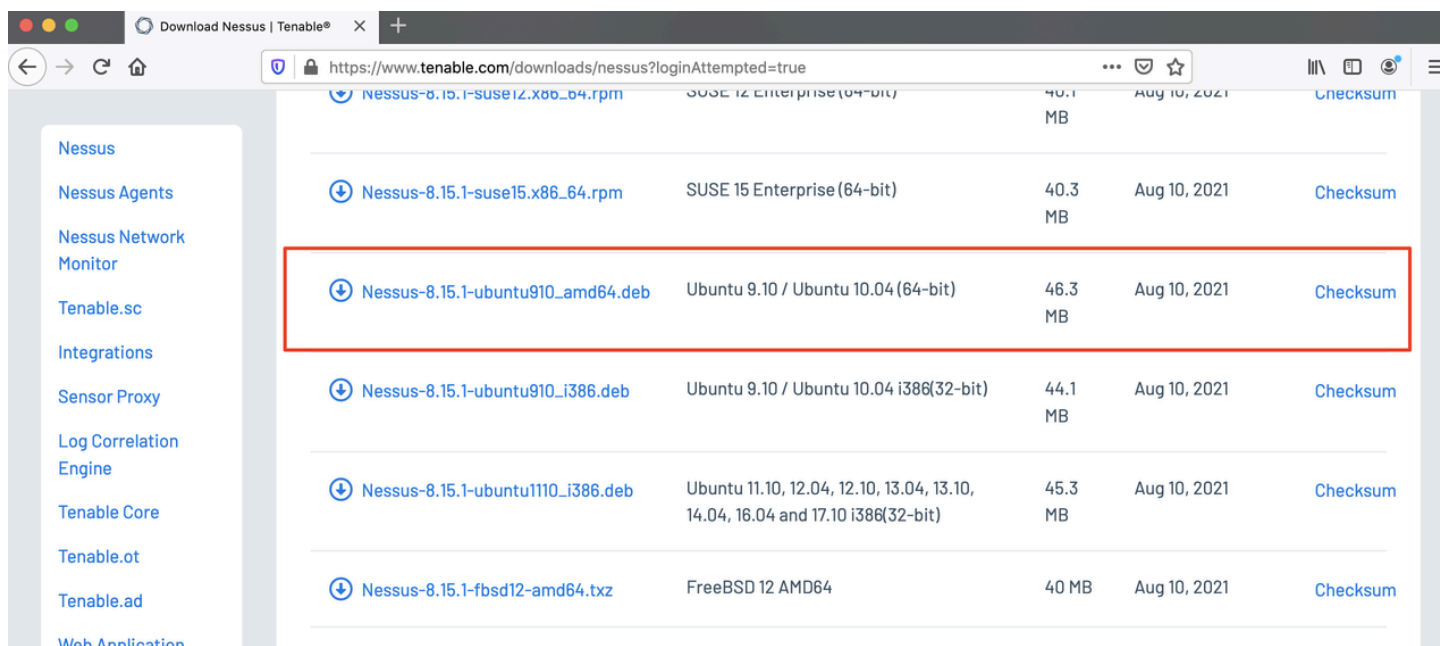
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Getting Started with Nessus

Let's see how we can download and set up Nessus for its first use so that we can start learning its various features. Feel free to follow along and set up a Nessus instance on your own VM. For the interactive portions of this course, we provide a lab instance of Nessus and another with OpenVAS installed.

Downloading Nessus

To download Nessus, we can navigate to its Download Page to download the correct Nessus binary for our system. We will be downloading the Debian package for Ubuntu for this walkthrough.



The screenshot shows the Nessus Download Page on the Tenable website. The page lists various operating system packages for download. The following table represents the data visible in the screenshot:

Package Name	Operating System	Size	Release Date	Checksum
Nessus-8.15.1-suse12.x86_64.rpm	SUSE 12 Enterprise (64-bit)	40.1 MB	Aug 10, 2021	Checksum
Nessus-8.15.1-suse15.x86_64.rpm	SUSE 15 Enterprise (64-bit)	40.3 MB	Aug 10, 2021	Checksum
Nessus-8.15.1-ubuntu910-amd64.deb	Ubuntu 9.10 / Ubuntu 10.04 (64-bit)	46.3 MB	Aug 10, 2021	Checksum
Nessus-8.15.1-ubuntu910-i386.deb	Ubuntu 9.10 / Ubuntu 10.04 i386(32-bit)	44.1 MB	Aug 10, 2021	Checksum
Nessus-8.15.1-ubuntu1110-i386.deb	Ubuntu 11.10, 12.04, 12.10, 13.04, 13.10, 14.04, 16.04 and 17.10 i386(32-bit)	45.3 MB	Aug 10, 2021	Checksum
Nessus-8.15.1-fbsd12-amd64.txz	FreeBSD 12 AMD64	40 MB	Aug 10, 2021	Checksum

Requesting Free License

Next, we can visit the Activation Code Page to request a Nessus Activation Code, which is necessary to get the free version of Nessus:



Nessus Professional

[Try for Free](#)[Buy Now](#)

Nessus Professional is for security pros on the front lines who need to quickly and easily identify and fix vulnerabilities - including software flaws, missing patches, malware, and misconfigurations - across a variety of operating systems, devices and applications.

For Consultants, Pen Testers and Security Practitioners

Nessus Professional Features

- Scan unlimited IPs
- Unlimited features, including Live Results and configuration auditing
- Accurate, high-speed asset discovery and broad coverage and profiling
- World's largest continuously-updated library of vulnerability and configuration checks

Nessus Essentials

[Register Now](#)

Nessus Essentials is a free vulnerability scanner that provides an entry point for vulnerability assessment. You get the same powerful scanner enjoyed by Nessus Professional subscribers, with the ability to scan 16 IPs.

For Educators, students and individuals starting their careers in Cyber Security

Nessus Essentials Features

- Scan 16 IPs
- High-speed, accurate assessment with thousands of vulnerability and configuration checks
- Agentless scanning of your network
- Support via the Tenable Community

[Downloads](#) / Nessus

Nessus

Need an Activation Code?

In order to complete your Nessus installation, you need an activation code if you don't have one already.

[Get Activation Code](#)

Nessus activation code prompt: 'Need an Activation Code? Get Activation Code button to complete installation.

Installing Package

With both the binary and activation code in hand, we can now install the Nessus package:

```
$ dpkg -i Nessus-8.15.1-ubuntu910_amd64.deb
```

Selecting previously unselected package nessus.

(Reading database ... 132030 files and directories currently installed.)

Preparing to unpack Nessus-8.15.1-ubuntu910_amd64.deb ...

Unpacking nessus (8.15.1) ...

Setting up nessus (8.15.1) ...

Unpacking Nessus Scanner Core Components...

Created symlink /etc/systemd/system/nessusd.service →
/lib/systemd/system/nessusd.service.

Created symlink /etc/systemd/system/multi-user.target.wants/nessusd.service →
/lib/systemd/system/nessusd.service.

Starting Nessus

Once we have Nessus installed, we can start the Nessus Service:

```
$ sudo systemctl start nessusd.service
```

Accessing Nessus

To access Nessus, we can navigate to <https://localhost:8834>. Once we arrive at the setup page, we should select Nessus Essentials for the free version, and then we can enter our activation code:



Welcome to Nessus

Choose how you want to deploy Nessus. Select a product to get started.

- ☒ Nessus Essentials
- ☐ Nessus Professional
- ☐ Nessus Manager
- ☐ Managed Scanner

Continue

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Once we enter our activation code, we can set up a user with a secure password for our Nessus account. Then, the plugins will begin to compile once this step is completed:



Initializing

Please wait while Nessus prepares the files needed to scan your assets.

Downloading plugins...



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Note: The VM provided at the Nessus Skills Assessment chapter has Nessus pre-installed and the targets running. You can go to that chapter and start the VM (click "Spawn target") and use Nessus throughout the course, which can be accessed at [https:// < IP >:8834](https://<IP>:8834). The Nessus credentials are: htb-student:HTB_@cademy_student!. You may also use these credentials to SSH into the target VM to configure Nessus.

Finally, once the setup is complete, we can start creating scans, scan policies, plugin rules, and customizing settings. The Settings page has a wealth of options such as setting up a Proxy Server or SMTP server, standard account management options, and advanced settings to customize the user interface, scanning, logging, performance, and security options.



Advanced Settings allow you to manually configure global settings. In order for these settings to take effect, a restart of the Nessus service or server may be required. NOTICE: Settings configured in scans or policies will override these values.

Search Settings

81 Settings

Setting	Identifier	Value	
Allow Post-Scan Editing	allow_post_scan_editing	Yes	
Disable API	disable_api	No	
Disable Frontend	disable_frontend	No	
Login Banner	login_banner		
Maximum Concurrent Web Users	global.max_web_users	1024	
Nessus Web Server IP	listen_address	0.0.0.0	
Nessus Web Server Port	xmlrpc_listen_port	8834	